My body was feeling that sludgy-thick opening that one feels when waking from an indeterminate amount of sleep. It could be minutes, hours or millennia. The big issue was that the room felt so bright and I couldn't bring myself to fully open my eyes. They resisted any attempt to force them open, snapping shut to defend against the piercing light of the outside world. As a secondary reaction, my arm attempted to lift my my hand to my face to shield my eyes. It resisted enough to need noticeable effort to oblige.

#

What is going on?

#

In that moment I also noticed my breathing was raspy and belabored. A ping of fear hit somewhere in my mind, but the focus on the effort to move sunk it back down before I could really grasp it. My whole body felt heavy and foreign, but I was finally able to lift my arm and shield my eyes. I looked out at a blurry world through cracks in my fingers and slitted eyes. Shapes refused to coagulate. I rubbed my eyes and attempted again, and again…

#

Slowly, the green smears along the walls resolved into plants. Sunlight spilled in through a wide window at the far end of the soft turquoise colored room, too bright to face directly.

#

The world was still focusing— rendering— when I brought my hands up to examine them. There was a small green bracelet around my left wrist that barely caught my attention when I noticed IVs sticking out of my arms; The IVs were pumping some clear liquid into me on my right arm and a purple liquid into my left.

#

Luckily I was propped up in a position that allowed me to swivel my head without having to use physical strength to lift my body first. I looked down at the rest of my body lying in a small bed in the middle of the room, covered by a white sheet. I had to fight my body once more when I tried to sit upright. My feeble arms resisted, but I overcame them.

#

I was starting to experience a particularly acute type of dread that comes when your consciousness opens into a hospital bed without memory of how you arrived there. In my case, the question of "who" escaped me as well. I attempted, but couldn't access any memory preceding my current awakening. Fearwas building.

#

I lifted a sheet that was wrapped over my body to reveal that I was wearing a light grey two piece outfit that felt very soft and breathable. It wasn't familiar either. I examined the rest of the room but didn't see any of the commonplace hospital items. My IV stretched away under my bed to some unforeseen end. I hurriedly examined each of my extremities by moving them to make sure my body still functioned and was without massive injury.

#

I wiggled my toes and moved my legs and arms and twisted me neck around. My body, though obstinate, moved when I attempted. I let out a sigh of relief.

#

That touch of relief left when I remembered that I couldn't remember why I was here or who I am. In a mild panic I swung my feet over the edge of the bed. They looked somewhat atrophied

and weak but I was determined to find answers somewhere. I wiggled my toes and spun my ankles to test them again. The floor felt soft against the bottom of my feet. It had the friction of rubber but the look of marble tile.

#

I leaned back onto my hands to start to lift and redirect my body weight onto my feet. As I did, there was hissing noise as a pocket door slid open on the wall in front of me. Walking through it was a dark featured woman carrying some sort of device like a tablet. She wore pastel salmon colored scrubs and had dreads tied into a bundle on top of her head with a few accents of beads and metal wraps. Her eyes were shining above a soft smile.

#

She spoke softly with a pleasant lilt.“Hello Christian!”

#

All I could muster was a confused stare at her.

#

“I saw on the monitors that you were awake…” She trailed off glancing down at a tablet-like device she was holding.

#

Her eyes lifted back toward me. “How are you feeling?”

#

Her accent was faint and unfamiliar, just enough to make certain words land noticeably differently.

#

I opened my mouth to speak but it felt like my throat was full of sand and I could only rasp out “I feel…” I coughed.

#

“I feel okay, but…” A coughing fit ended my ability to talk.

#

She had a concerned look on her face, “I’m sorry, you don’t have to try to talk right now. I’m sure your throat is dry, and you’re disoriented.”

#

She crossed to a sink built into the wall and pressed a small button. Water streamed into a metal cup she found on a small shelf beside the sink.

#

The sound of the water rising in the cup climbed in pitch as she spoke. “Give yourself a little time.”

#

She brought the cup over while I rubbed my throat and tried to clear it with a few smaller coughs.

#

“Here is some water.” She radiated a kind disarming nature.

#

I didn’t realize how thirsty I was until the liquid hit my lips. I drank too fast to breathe and had to gasp when I finished. The water tasted faintly sweet.

#

As I chugged she asked, “Do you remember me?”

#

I wished I could be polite and switch over to the conversation but I chugged the water while she waited for my response.

#

After the cup was finished I shook my head as I attempted, and decided against, trying to speak.

#

She gave a compassionate nod “I know this is all probably quite disorienting. You are in a good place though. I promise. We will make sure you have a smooth recovery.”

#

After I had finished gasping for air and clearing my throat again, through belabored breath, I asked for another.

#

She only smiled and replied. “I will gladly grab you another after that drink settles a bit. You’ve been asleep for quite a while and I want to make sure your stomach can handle it before we fill it up.”

#

I spoke again, this time with slightly less difficulty but with a slap of mucus in my throat “What happen...” I was cut off by coughs again.

#

While I was speaking — then coughing — she looked concerned then to her tablet. “One moment” she said as she read the screen. “You have some memory loss. Don’t worry, this is

completely normal and it's often temporary."

#

"Often temp…?" I said my stress rising again and my throat seeming to restrict with it.

#

Her tone and demeanor softened to a more reassuring one, "Your brain structure is fully functional and intact. Sometimes full cognitive function just takes a little while, and sometimes memories can be jogged later, reopening mental pathways that seemed to be closed. I think you'll recover fine with time."

#

I spoke through a sandy throat. "What… happened? "

#

She gave a soft sigh, "I personally don't know all of the details but someone else will… but it is most important now to rest. If you need us for anything there is a button… oh."

#

Her arm extended under the bed and pulled up a small sort of railing that locked into place. There were multiple buttons on it with different pictographs. "Here they are."

#

"This one is to call one of us. This one is to call for dietary… for food, and this one is if you're having any pain." She pointed to each button as she explained them.

#

"I can't… remember." I said through gravel.

#

Her face looked focused and slightly concerned as she was distracted by her tablet again. “Well your name is Christian Talima. The rest will come with time. For now, just focus on rest.”

#

Fear tightened my throat and stomach again.

#

Why can’t I remember anything?

#

“I want to… walk.” I said, starting to put weight onto my legs.

#

Pain shoot through them that almost toppled me, but the doctor quickly grasped me before I could fall all the way.

#

“Your limbs have atrophied.” She paused as most of her strength and focused on helping me back into bed.

#

I apologized as I tried to use my arms now to help her lift me back into the bed.

#

She continued, “You’re on a therapy that will get your body back into shape pretty rapidly… but it means you need rest for now, and trust.” Her hand was resting on my shoulder in a stabilizing manner. I only nodded dejectedly. “Please just give it a bit more time.”

#

I would have probably had a million more questions, but my throat wasn’t working to speak, my

body was failing me in simple tasks and my memories had been wiped clean. I felt deeply overwhelmed, and a mixture of anxious fire quelling with a watery sleepiness.

#

She was looking at the screen in front of her, touching parts of it. Her face was making various expressions of concentration and satisfaction as she nodded. My mind settled onto my thirst and I interrupted, my voice still belabored,"How long… till more water?"

#

She gave her full attention to me very deliberately, "How does your stomach feel?"

#

"Fine…"

#

"Well we should…" She started but I interrupted.

#

"Actually… there is a… a tingle…"

#

I gestured toward my throat, "Here…", then my stomach, "here." I waved my hands gesturing to my general body. "Kind of… everywhere."

#

"That sounds like the therapy is active. I adjusted it. Your body just getting used to it. I still think we should just wait a little…"

#

I instinctively looked down at the purple IV in my left arm. The green braided bracelet caught

my attention again.

#

She looked at the screen again, then back to me, “Lets say another hour. If you’re worried about hydration, the IV is handling that.”

#

She was smiling again as she gestured to my arm. I reflexively lifted it to look again at the IV.

#

I just realized that I didn’t really have an appetite, but maybe food would feel good.

#

“Food?… No?” I forced.

#

She looked a little solemn and shook her head. “I can bring you a small meal a bit later. It will be a nutritional soup and some more water and tea if you’d like. It really won’t be long and you’ll be back to normal or even better; eating and drinking whatever you want.”

#

I nodded, giving in to her authority as caretaker. I felt an odd sense of deep relaxation and wondered what she’d put in my IV to bring this warm calm feeling.

#

“If you need anything, just press the button.” She gestured again toward the button on the railing.

#

“But for now, just try to get some rest.”

#

She promised to bring back some entertainment as she left the room. This gave me more time to orient myself in this new space. I studied the light turquoise colored room in the golden hour sunlight.

#

I could see the top of a tree swaying outside the window, dyed a similar sunset orange to the rest of the room. I must be a few stories up. I stared at the swaying tree for a moment, caught in the rythme, before I noticed a low humming noise. The room seemed to swell now: pulling toward me then pushing back out with each breath. The plants were mirroring me, waving, kind and calming.

#

My vision tried to blurr and my eyes to shut, but I forced them back open. For a moment the room returned to the less psychedelic feeling and my anxiety set back in, but the walls quickly melted back and my eyes slammed shut.